

NO VACANCY:
Muhachak
Jamsaut
villagers show
their job cards

SOP OPERA

REALITY CHECK

Dream schemes that look perfect on paper do not always deliver a better life for the people

This is the India that exists only in the Planning Commission's PowerPoint presentations. Where, even after the farm loan waiver, Vangeti Bhoopal Reddy from Godamakunta village in Andhra Pradesh's Ranga Reddy district has to sell an acre of land to fund his son's education. Where Deepshikha School in the heart of Bhopal would still be struggling to pay for chalk without the Sarva Shiksha Abhiyan. Where a little government funding can go a long way. The trouble is most schemes to disseminate that funding look flawless—but only on paper. Almost everywhere, a government scheme is as successful as its driver on the ground. At times the scheme acts as an enabler for a change, as in Mumbai, where machines are boring into the depths of the city to replace ancient water supply pipelines under the Jawaharlal Nehru National Urban Renewal Mission. At times it acts as a motivator, as in Agara in Karnataka, where hot cooked meals under the Midday Meals Scheme have doubled the number of school students in the local village school. And yet, at other times, it just comes apart, as in Rajasthan's Sanwlia village, where a change of sarpanch has meant that the village has been dry for the past four months though it is part of the Rajiv Gandhi Drinking Water Mission. Does the Government's generosity percolate from the coffers to the core? INDIA TODAY reporters across the country investigate.

NO GUARANTEES

Muhachak Jamsaut, Bihar

**NATIONAL RURAL EMPLOYMENT
GUARANTEE SCHEME**

**Budget allocation for 2008-09
Rs 16,000 crore**

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Lalmati Devi, 30, is furious. Her brother Chandrashekhar, a job card holder under the National Rural Employment Guarantee Scheme (NREGS), has been visiting the mukhiya's home for over a year now. He has not been able to find work so far. About 20